

Castle Encounters

Most castles in the wilderness will belong to high level NPCs who have cleared the land and hired mercenaries. When characters discover a castle in the wilderness they will be unsure of the type of reception they will receive. If the DM has not planned the reaction of the inhabitants of a castle the following table may be used. To use the table, find the character type that inhabits the castle. For each character class the type of men that will be found with the lord of the castle will be listed, and the reaction of the lord. These reactions assume the party does nothing either to arouse suspicion or inspire trust. Note that the men listed are only part of the castle owner's forces. The rest of the force should include men and might even include special creatures such as trolls, or combinations such as superheroes mounted on griffons.

Owner	Level	Patrol	Pursue	Ignore	Friendly
Fighter	9-14	2-12 heavy horsemen	1-3	4-5	6
Magic-User	11-14	2-12 heavy footmen	1	2-5	6
Cleric	7-14	2-12 medium horsemen	1-2	3-4	5-6

Pursue. The men will chase the party off the lord's land or charge the characters a toll. This sum may vary depending on the personality of the lord, how wealthy the characters look, and other things. Refusing to pay may result in being arrested, run off the land, or attacked.

Ignore. This means that no attempt to aid or hinder the party will be made.

Friendly. This result does not necessarily mean that the castle owner likes the adventurers. It merely indicates that he or she has invited them to stay. Some NPCs may do this for evil purposes.

Elves, dwarves, and halflings are not given on this list, as their strongholds are special cases. In almost all cases these characters will seek to avoid contact with strangers. The DM should detail any non-human strongholds so that definite reactions may be known.

DUNGEON MASTERING AS A FINE ART

The guidelines given in the D&D Basic booklet are even more important in a wilderness campaign. Part of the art of expert DMing is to keep the campaign challenging for the players. Much of the rest is dealing with balance problems: too much money, not enough money, a too-powerful magic item, a too-powerful character, player grudges, and so forth. Many of the answers to these problems, as well as a personal DMing style, will come through continued play.

"But I rolled it!" A common mistake most DMs make is to rely too much on random die rolls. An entire evening can be spoiled if an unplanned wilderness encounter on the way to the dungeon goes badly for the party. The DM must use good judgment in addition to random tables. Encounters should be scaled to the strength of the party and should be in harmony with the theme of the adventure.

"Monsters use teamwork, too." A player character party with a wide range of abilities can usually defeat any single monster opponent. Thus, monsters will often team up for mutual survival. Special groups of monsters combining missile, spell, and melee attacks can be set up. Also, monsters can be given special leaders

with more hit dice (or maximum hit points) and other special abilities. For example: a magic-user with two apprentices, a bodyguard of bugbears, and a charmed mantichore; or an orc leader with clerical spells leading a party of bow-armed orcs with trained hunting lizards; and so on.

"The most dangerous game." Only non-intelligent monsters should act unintelligently. Weak monsters will use missile weapons, traps, ambushes, and even make deals — slugging it out with a more powerful party will only get them massacred! A strong monster will have guards to weaken a party or guard its escape. Smart monsters will use any magic items in their lairs that they can to best advantage. If the party fails to defeat a monster, it will prepare defenses, get reinforcements, or even move to another area in case the party returns. Surviving monsters will learn from a party's tactics and be prepared to imitate or counter them next time.

"NPCs are people, too!" NPCs should be played by the DM as intelligent people with interests of their own. If a player tries to convince an NPC to do something, the DM should think about how a player would react to the same offer, considering character and alignment of the NPC. Also remember that NPCs have friends that will help (or avenge) them, and that NPCs may have friends or retainers with them when encountered. Permanent NPC retainers will expect to be outfitted and supported by their employer. They will want a share of the treasure (not less than half the share of a player character) and will expect to be well-led and brought back alive.

"Can I do this?" The DM should be *very* careful when letting the players develop new spells, new magic, and expanded abilities. Permanent abilities, unlimited uses, and effects that increase with level or have no saving throw can lead to massive imbalances. In some cases, the DM may want to test an idea for a given time with the understanding that changes will be made if necessary.

"I wish" **Wishes** can cause problems if not handled properly. The DM must see that **wishes** are reasonably limited or the balance and enjoyment of the game will be completely upset. The DM should not allow wishes that alter the basics of the game. (For example, a **wish** that all dragons can't breath fire.) The more unreasonable and greedy the wish is, the less likely it is that the **wish** will become reality. For example if a character should wish for a magic weapon to fight the werewolves attacking the party, the DM may see this as reasonable and a +1 sword might appear, *disappearing* when the fight is over. If a player were to wish for a life draining sword, it too might appear, in the hands of a fearsome opponent.

The wording of a **wish** is very important and can greatly alter the results. Wishing for more wishes will certainly place the character in an endless time loop, forever repeating the acquisition and use of the **wish**. However, wishing that certain monsters had never attacked, or the blow that killed Laurencino the Thief had never landed, are acceptable and good uses of a wish.

"Pay the piper." When taking excess money out of the campaign, never just take it away from a character. Instead, present the player with a number of choices (based logically on the character's own actions, if possible) of which the least painful is giving up money. It is important *not* to directly force the players into a pre-decided course of action. For example, a treasure-laden fighting-man just back from a dungeon is confronted with the local salvage tax. He can refuse to pay (and face arrest and possible confinement), he can attempt to flee back into the wilderness (a dangerous course, uncertain of success), or he can pay up and try to look happy about it.